Lord Buddha plus a cutout of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, reflecting the CM's spiritual side and his pride over his community, the Patidars. A giant TV screen occupies a side of the wall in front of the CM's chair. The balcony has a wooden swing and offers a spectacular view of the state secretariat. Patel has chosen Mondays and Tuesdays for his meet-the-people sessions, possibly so that he can take their feedback before the weekly cabinet meeting on Wednesday. "*Vat paadi des tamaara* (I will get you weight at home)," he tells the people. He believes the visitors would get respect in their villages or towns if they are seen to have access to the CM.

Slow pace, focused areas

The soft-spoken Bhupendra Patel is the first Gujarat CM to prefer trousers and shirts over the traditional kurta-pyjma. He is also known to be circumspect about bold administrative decisions. "What is the hurry? I am here to play a Test, not a T-20, match," he apparently told a group of real estate developers at a meeting last year. What he has done is travel widely in the state to get to know the people outside Ahmedabad. The CM's office rolls out the figures—Patel has travelled 61,000 km, interacted with 22,000 people and attended 300 government/private meetings in the first 200 days of his tenure. He also claims credit for transparency in transfers and postings of government staff (the Dhrumil Patel scandal notwithstanding). Indeed, on May 28, 1,051 state employees were transferred within their districts. "It was the first time that such large-scale transfers took place in 24 hours, and through the online method," states a note issued by the CM's office.

On his trips, the CM has also made unannounced stops at public construction sites for inspections; his visit to the Rajkot-Ahmedabad highway site in January had made news. Critics, though, say his trips are more about

HITS AND MISSES

MODI STAMP

Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel too has reaped the fruits of four schemes PM Narendra Modi launched when he headed the state between 2002 and 2014

↘ Seva Setu

The digital platform has been the biggest hit,offering 99 per cent of basic services, like change in name, adding beneficiaries to schemes etc.

↘ Garib Kalyan Mela

Provides financial assistance to needy and poor people; has benefited 14.7 million people with disbursal of Rs 26,600 crore in 12 years

↘ Van Bandhu Kalyan Yojana

Aimed at doubling the income of tribal families. Under the scheme, 1.1 million acres of farmland in tribal areas has been irrigated

↘ Tap water scheme

The ambitious project is near completion with 90 per cent of the population having access to tapped drinking water. The target of 100 per cent is likely to be completed by September

PATEL FORMULA

The big schemes launched since the CM took over in September 2021

↘ Mehsul Mela (revenue fair)

Since February, a revenue fair has been held in each district once a month to deliver services on the spot. So far, 5,000 people have benefited from the scheme

↘ Niramay Gujarat

The scheme includes free screening for non-communicable diseases for people above 30. Since Nov. 2021, 1 million people have been screened

↘ Suposhit Mata Swasth Bal Yojana

From FY 2022-23, every expectant/new mother will get free rations for 1,000 days; some 1.7 million women could benefit from the scheme

↘ New universities

This year, permission has been granted for 11 private universities, taking their number to 63. This is a big chunk in the total 93 universities in the state

NEW LOW

The CM has been facing flak for neglecting the underprivileged sections of society

↘ Atrocities against SCs

Gujarat has been reporting an average five cases a month. The government has failed to punish the culprits

↘ Hiding Covid death nos.

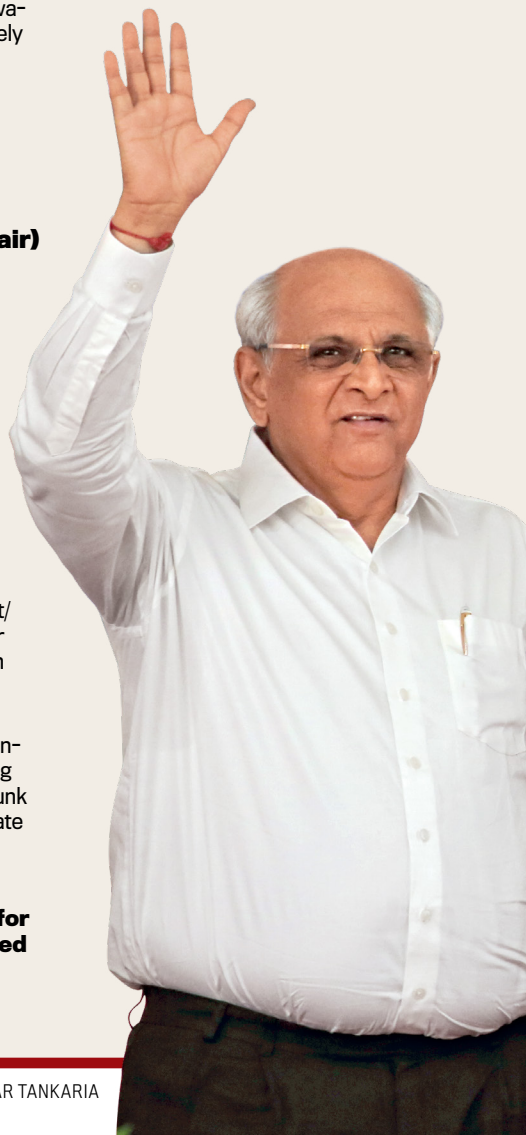
The state's claim that Gujarat had only 10,164 Covid deaths as of January 17, was belied by its own affidavit before the SC that stated it had received 102,230 Covid death claims and approved 87,085 of them

↘ Paper leak cases

Almost every recruitment drive has been marred by exam paper leaks in the past four months

↘ Bad boys

At least three ministers—Arvind Raiyani, Jitu Vaghani and Gajendrasinh Parmar—have brought a bad name to the government in the past three months through their controversial behaviour and remarks



TUSHAR TANKARIA